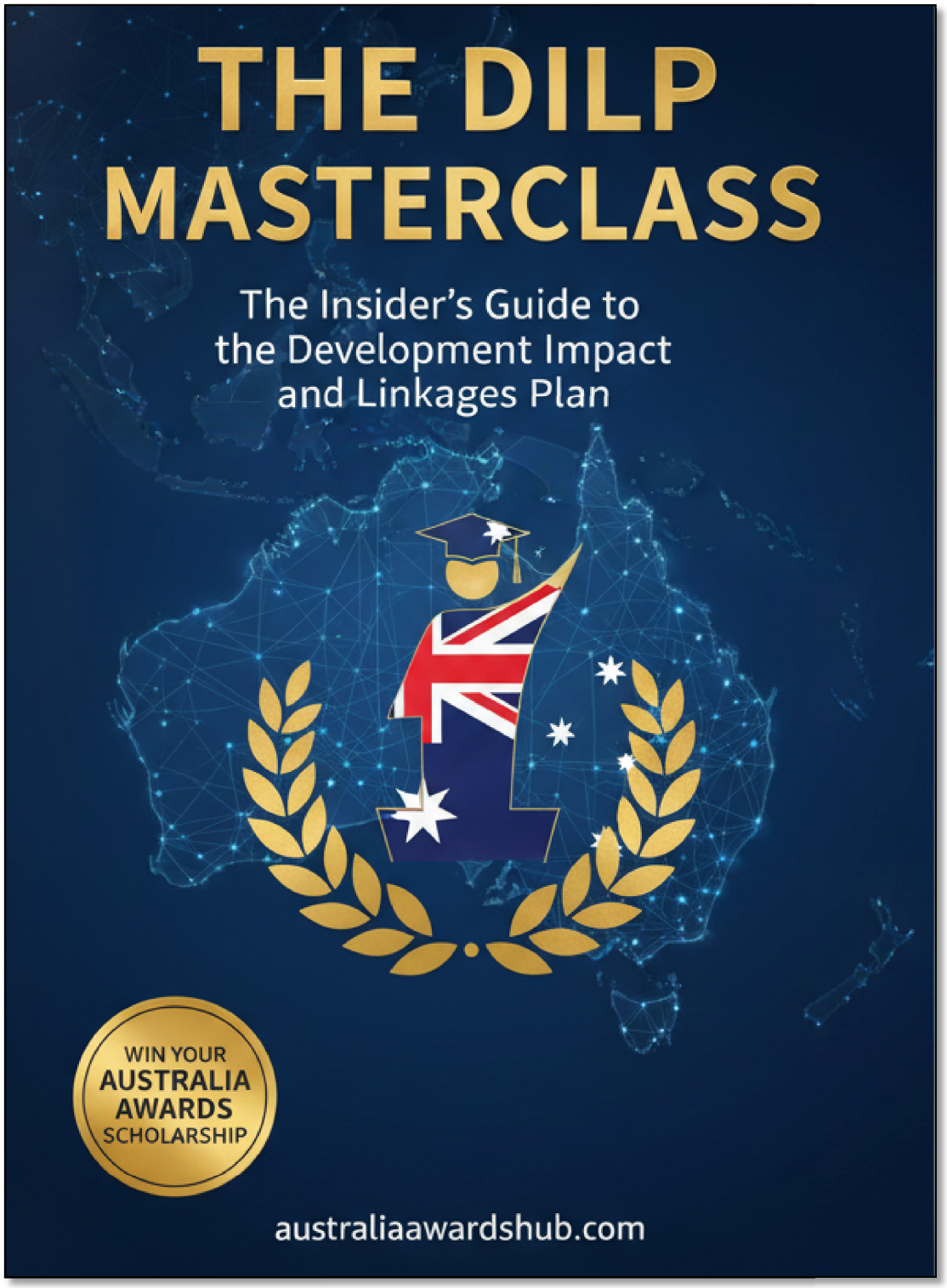
THE DILP
MASTERCLASS
The Insider's Guide to
the Development Impact
and Linkages Plan
WIN YOUR
AUSTRALIA
AWARDS
SCHOLARSHIP
australiaawardshub.com

About This Guide

Win Your Australia Awards Scholarship: The Insider DILP Guide That Gets You Selected is published by Australia Awards Hub (australiaawardshub.com). This is an independent educational resource not affiliated with DFAT, the Australian Government, or any Australian university.

All DILP examples are anonymised composites from successful applications. No personal information is reproduced. Scholarship requirements, priority sectors, deadlines, and processes are subject to change. Always verify current requirements at dfat.gov.au before submitting your application.

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CHAPTER 01

What Is the DILP?

The document that DFAT scores most carefully

Breaking Down the Name

The Development Impact and Linkages Plan (DILP) is mandatory for applicants from many countries including Pakistan, Bangladesh, Indonesia, Vietnam, and others. Submitted through OASIS by 30 April at 14:00 AEST. Unlike your transcript or English test, the DILP is actively scored. It is the document where your application is made or broken.

Word	Meaning	What assessors look for
Development	Positive contribution to your country's development after returning	A real, specific local problem — not a vague national aspiration
Impact	The measurable difference your activities make to real people	Concrete, quantifiable outcomes — not "I will help people"
Linkages	Enduring connections you will build in Australia	Specific organisations beyond your campus — government, business, professional bodies
Plan	Detailed proposal with activities, timeline, partners, and measures of success	Practical, doable, within your own capacity — not a wish list

The Two-Part Structure

Part 1 covers what you will do in Australia. Part 2 covers what you will do on return. Everything in Part 1 must set up Part 2 — assessors look for a coherent narrative connecting both parts.

Critical fact — the DILP is formally scored

A strong DILP from a moderately competitive candidate can win the scholarship. A weak DILP from an outstanding candidate can lose it. Give it the attention it deserves.

CHAPTER 02

The Assessor Speaks

What DFAT scholarship evaluators actually look for

Australia Awards Hub are international scholarship consultants who undertake assessment of DILP and guide applicants about winning DILPs from rejected ones.

> *"DILP is an important part of the application process. Give it your close attention. Make a draft, put it aside. Come back to it later. Maybe have someone you trust read it and give you feedback. Don't leave it until the last minute."*

The Four Questions Every Winning DILP Answers

1 What is the problem?

Not a national challenge — a specific, named, local problem you personally encounter in your job. "Pakistan faces water challenges" tells an assessor nothing. "The water infiltration gallery serving 7,200 residents in my township is contaminated by untreated tributary waste" tells them everything.

2 How can I contribute to addressing the problem?

Your contribution must be directly connected to your professional role and authority. Generic contributions are not convincing. The assessor must be able to picture you returning to your actual job and implementing your actual plan.

3 Is my plan practical, doable, and within my own capacity?

These exact words appear in the official DILP template. Every activity you propose must be something you as an individual can realistically initiate and complete in your current role. Activities that require a minister's decision or a new law fail this test.

4 What are the measures of success?

Measures of success refer to the way that others will see the evidence of your achievement. They must be specific enough to measure your individual contribution — not broad national statistics unrelated to your project.

> *"Think about what you as an individual could potentially achieve. Your contribution is something which can be influenced by you as an individual. You don't have to be the highest achieving alumnus immediately on return from your Australia Awards Scholarship."*

Start with your measures of success

Thinking about your measures of success early helps you structure your entire DILP. When you know what evidence of success looks like, work backwards to define the activities that produce it. Ask: "How will I know it worked?" — then build your plan to get there.

CHAPTER 03

Part 1 — Preparing for Your Scholarship

Priority sectors, competencies, and your planned contribution

Priority Sector Selection — A Strategic Decision

You select up to two priority sectors. Only tick sectors where you have direct professional experience AND where your proposed course clearly applies. Assessors look for coherence between your job, your sectors, your course and your plan.

Sector	Best suited for
Water Security	Civil engineers, environmental engineers, public health professionals, water sector workers
Infrastructure	Civil engineers, urban planners, local government professionals, transport engineers
Climate Change	Environmental professionals, disaster risk specialists, climate adaptation workers
Health & Nutrition	Medical professionals, public health workers, nutritionists, health system administrators
Education	Teachers, school administrators, curriculum developers, education policy professionals
Agriculture	Agronomists, food security workers, rural development professionals, veterinarians
Empowerment of Women & Girls	Gender equity specialists, social workers, women's health professionals
Inclusive Economic Development	Economists, finance professionals, private sector development workers

Your Planned Contribution (250–500 words)

WORD LIMIT: 250–500 words

This is where most applicants write generic, forgettable content. The winning approach is radical specificity: describe a real problem you face every day in your actual job — not a national issue.

✕ Weak — generic and forgettable | **AVOID THIS**

"Bangladesh faces significant challenges in water supply and sanitation. After my scholarship, I plan to use my knowledge to improve water and sanitation systems in Bangladesh."

✓ **Strong — specific, credible, evidence-based** **WINNING APPROACH**

"I currently work as a technical officer in a municipal development authority responsible for infrastructure and public services for a township of approximately 7,200 residents. Two urgent problems face this community that I am directly responsible for addressing.

First, the water supply infiltration gallery is contaminated by untreated waste from tributaries — a design flaw posing serious health risks. Second, the sewerage network has no functioning disposal mechanism.

After completing my Masters in Environmental Engineering, I will design and implement: (a) a water supply upgrade, and (b) a sustainable sewage disposal system. Both are already in the Annual Development Plan — but cannot proceed due to insufficient technical expertise. My scholarship provides exactly that expertise."

CHAPTER 04

Linkages: The Most Underused Winning Advantage

How to demonstrate enduring connections beyond your academic campus

> *"It's important to think about how you will maximise the opportunity of living in Australia beyond the confines of the academic campus. The connections you make could be with individuals, with government organisations, and with businesses — but they won't necessarily all be connections made on your campus."*

Eight Linkage Types — From the Official Assessor

We have identified these linkage activities as options. Choose 2–3 that suit your professional context:

Linkage type	Detail and examples
Volunteer with a community organisation	Multicultural associations, environmental groups, local councils. Connects you with Australians across all backgrounds.
Join a professional association	Engineers Australia, AMA, Teachers Federation. Membership gives networking and continuing professional development.
Attend conferences and seminars	Professional conferences in your field. One or two provide direct access to practitioners and researchers.
Join a special interest group	Water engineering networks, public health forums, education policy roundtables — communities of practice in your field.
Work placement or internship	Approaching a government agency, utility, or NGO for a placement during semester breaks. Start outreach 6 months early.

Linkage type	Detail and examples
Find a professional mentor	A senior Australian professional who meets with you regularly. These relationships often last decades.
Join your home country business council	Australia-Pakistan Business Council and equivalents. Often overlooked but providing exceptional networking.
Sports teams and outdoor activities	Specific mention to this as offering "unexpected linkage opportunities" with Australians you would never meet through university.

How to write your linkages plan

Name the specific organisation. Describe the specific engagement. Explain why it is relevant to your DILP plan. "I will seek an internship at [City Water Corporation] to observe water treatment processes applicable to the system I will design on return" is far stronger than "I will visit Australian water companies."

CHAPTER 05

Part 2 — Your Development Leadership Plan

The most heavily scored section — your plan for impact on return

> *"Your planned contribution must be practical, doable, and within your own capacity. Think about what you as an individual could potentially achieve. What could realistically be achieved within about two years after your return?"*

Title of Your Proposed Activity

✗ Weak title — AVOID THIS

"Improving water in Indonesia"

☑ Strong title — WINNING APPROACH

"Upgrade and improvement of water supply and sewerage network in [specific type of area / municipality / region]"

Rationale and Intended Outcomes (500 words)

WORD LIMIT: 500 words — address all four elements

1 The specific problem

Name it. Quantify it. Who is affected? How many people? What is the cause? Why has it not been fixed?

2 Why it matters

Connect to public health, economic productivity, national development priorities, or environmental sustainability. What happens if nothing is done?

3 How your Australia Awards experience helps

Link your course content AND your linkages plan specifically. Not "my degree will help me" — but "the [X module] plus my internship at [Y] will give me the skills to design [Z]."

4 What you will achieve

Concrete, measurable changes: cleaner water quality test results, reduced disease rates, number of people with improved access.

Activities and Tasks (500 words)

WORD LIMIT: 500 words — everything within your own capacity

The "within your own capacity" test

"Can I do this on my own initiative, in my current role, without requiring someone else's decision?" Design a system, prepare a proposal, train colleagues — PASS. "The government will build a national system" — FAIL.

Strong example activities list:

- Design a water supply system to remove contamination from the water source
- Prepare and submit a project proposal for funding approval
- Design a safe sewage disposal system for the target community
- Train other technical officers on water and sewage management best practices
- Organise community awareness events with the local residents' association
- Maintain ongoing collaboration with Australian contacts established during the scholarship
- Collect resident feedback through structured surveys at 6 and 12 months

Measures of Success

Measures of success must show the way others will see the evidence of your achievement. They must be specific to your project — not broad national statistics.

✓ Strong measures — concrete and verifiable	WINNING APPROACH

✓ Consistent improvement in water quality test results at source over 12 months

✓ Reduction in resident complaints about water quality through the official portal

✓ Measurable decrease in reported waterborne disease cases in the target community

✓ Resident satisfaction survey results at 6 and 12 months post-implementation

Challenges and Risks

The template asks for three challenges and their mitigating actions. It specifically asks how climate change might affect your plan. Many applicants skip this — it costs points.

✓ Strong challenges section — honest, specific, with credible mitigations	WINNING APPROACH

Challenge 1: Inadequate funding through the Budget

Mitigation: Authority has self-financing capacity and can supplement through rate adjustments. Projects submitted for formal budget allocation.

Challenge 2: Operations and Maintenance after project completion

Mitigation: O&M staff trained before and after completion. Ongoing collaboration with Australian contacts. Climate-resilient design from outset.

Challenge 3: Community resistance to land acquisition

Mitigation: Proactive community engagement from planning stage. Clear communication of health benefits and consequences of non-implementation.

CHAPTER 06

Winning Examples: Section-by-Section Analysis

Real DILP sections from a successful application — anonymised and annotated

The following complete section responses are drawn from a successful Australia Awards scholarship application, fully anonymised. Each is followed by an analysis of exactly why it works.

Planned Contribution to Country's Development

✓ Winning response — Planned Contribution | WINNING APPROACH

"I currently work as a technical officer in a department responsible for infrastructure and public services in a small town of 5000 residents. Two urgent, interconnected problems currently face this community.

First, the existing water supply system draws from an infiltration gallery contaminated by untreated waste from nearby tributaries — a design oversight posing serious public health risks. Second, the sewerage network has no functioning disposal mechanism: untreated sewage enters the groundwater system, potentially spreading waterborne diseases including cholera.

After completing my Masters in Environmental Engineering, I will design and implement two specific projects: (a) a water supply system upgrade to remove contamination from the source, and (b) a sustainable sewage disposal system. Both projects are already listed as priorities in the Annual Plan — but cannot be implemented due to insufficient technical expertise in the department. My scholarship provides exactly that expertise."

Why it works

✓ Names a real, specific professional role ✓ Quantifies the affected community (5000 residents) ✓ Identifies the precise technical gap ✓ Projects are already in the official pipeline — waiting only for the scholarship's skills ✓ The connection between study and impact is direct and undeniable

Activities and Tasks

✓ Winning response — Activities | WINNING APPROACH

1. Design a water supply system to remove contamination from the infiltration gallery
2. Prepare and submit a project proposal for Annual Development Plan funding approval
3. Supervise execution and monitor via regular independent water quality tests
4. Design a safe sewage disposal system for the township
5. Submit a second ADP proposal for sewage system funding
6. Supervise sewage system implementation; monitor groundwater impact
7. Train other departmental officers on water and sewage management best practices
8. Organise community awareness events with Residents' Welfare Association
9. Collaborate with Australian contacts established during scholarship for ongoing technical guidance
10. Collect resident feedback through structured surveys to measure project impact

Why it works

✓Every activity is within the applicant's own professional authority ✓Logical progression: design → fund → build → monitor → train → community → sustain ✓Activity 9 integrates the linkages plan into the return plan — they connect ✓Activity 10 sets up the measures of success — the plan is internally coherent

CHAPTER 07

Scale Your Goals

The assessor's own real examples from applications

> *"Some of these goals are very big, very ambitious. Think about what is practical, achievable, and within my capacity. Be specific. Keep your goal manageable."*

Actual examples of over-ambitious goals she has seen in applications, alongside achievable alternatives:

Too ambitious — avoid	Better — specific, individual, achievable
To eliminate tax avoidance	To improve duty screening procedures for the import of [X product] in [X region] through the following approach
To provide universal healthcare for all citizens	To identify underutilization of [X health services] among [Y population] and implement the following steps
To reduce road vehicle accidents to zero	To target vehicle accident hotspots in [X region] and reduce incidents through the following strategy
To reverse climate change	To address [a specific climate-related problem] in [X region] and implement an awareness strategy to change [Y behaviours]
To eliminate infant and maternal mortality	To improve the uptake of child vaccination rates in [X region] using the following strategy
To solve the water crisis in my country	To design and implement a water supply upgrade for [X community] to address [Z specific contamination problem]
To transform the national education system	To improve teacher professional development attendance in [X district] by implementing [Y training programme]

The pattern to apply to any goal

Take your ambitious goal. Ask: "What specific, local version of this problem exists in my direct work area?" Then ask: "What specific activities — that I personally can initiate and complete within two years — would address that local version?" That is your DILP goal. Specific. Manageable. Yours.

CHAPTER 08

Field-by-Field DILP Guide

Guidance for health, education, engineering, agriculture and governance

Engineering and Infrastructure

The strongest field — problems are concrete, measurable, and tied to specific technical skills.

Element	Guidance
Problem example	A water supply network with contamination; a road in dangerous condition; a stormwater system causing flooding
Australian linkage	Relevant engineering firm, utility company, or local government engineering department
Measures of success	Infrastructure quality tests, number of beneficiaries, incident reduction data, water quality parameters
Key phrase	"I will design [X] for [Y community] to address [Z specific problem], financed through [specific funding mechanism]"

Health and Public Health

Focus on a specific health system gap in your direct work context — not a national health challenge.

Element	Guidance
Problem example	A facility with no disease surveillance; high maternal mortality in your district; broken vaccine cold chain
Australian linkage	Hospital, public health agency, university health research centre, or community health organisation
Measures of success	Disease incidence rates, facility utilisation data, vaccination coverage, number of health workers trained
Key phrase	"To identify underutilisation of [X service] among [Y population] and implement [Z strategy] to achieve [measurable outcome]"

Education

Focus on an observable, specific gap in your school, district, or curriculum — not "the education system."

Element	Guidance
Problem example	Teacher professional development absent in your district; digital learning missing in N schools; girls' dropout above national average
Australian linkage	University education faculty, school system, teacher training organisation
Measures of success	Number of teachers trained, student retention rates, literacy improvement, attendance data

Element	Guidance
Key phrase	"To improve [specific outcome] among [N teachers/students] in [Z district] by implementing [specific intervention]"

Agriculture and Food Security

Focus on a specific crop, region, farming community, or supply chain gap.

Element	Guidance
Problem example	Smallholder yield below potential due to lack of [X technique]; post-harvest losses exceeding X% due to inadequate storage
Australian linkage	Agricultural research institutes, university agronomy departments, farming cooperatives
Measures of success	Yield improvement %, adoption rate of new practices, post-harvest loss reduction, household income change
Key phrase	"To improve [crop] yields among [N farmers] in [X region] through [Y specific method]"

Governance and Public Policy

Hardest field — outputs are less tangible. Produce something concrete: a document, a reformed process, a trained team.

Element	Guidance
Problem example	A regulation not being enforced; a process causing delays; a policy not reaching target beneficiaries
Australian linkage	Government departments, public administration schools, think tanks, regulatory bodies
Measures of success	Policy document produced, process improvement metrics, number of staff trained, formal adoption of new procedure
Key phrase	"To reform [X process] in [Y department] by implementing [Z methodology] and measure via [specific operational metric]"

CHAPTER 09

9 Mistakes That Cost Applicants the Scholarship

The errors assessors see most often — and exactly how to fix them

1

Mistake: Too vague

"I will contribute to Vietnam's development in the water sector."

Fix: Name the problem, location, population affected, your role, and specific activities.

2

Mistake: No link to your actual job

Proposing a project in a sector you don't work in, or activities you couldn't initiate.

Fix: Your DILP must be grounded in your actual professional context. The assessor must believe you will return to your job and do this.

3

Mistake: Activities beyond your authority

"The government will build a new national treatment system."

Fix: Every activity must be something you personally can initiate and complete within your current role and authority.

4

Mistake: Unmeasurable outcomes

"Residents will have better health."

Fix: Every outcome needs a specific, observable measure: a quality test result, a disease rate, a number of people trained.

5

Mistake: Generic Australian linkages

"I will visit Australian universities."

Fix: Name the specific organisation. Describe the specific engagement. Explain why it is relevant to your plan.

6

Mistake: Skipping the climate change prompt

Many applicants leave the climate change section blank — it costs points.

Fix: Identify which climate risks affect your project area and explain how your activities are designed to be resilient.

7

Mistake: Over-ambitious timeline

A plan to transform an entire city's infrastructure within 6 months of returning.

Fix: Plan for two years: Design Phase (3–4 months) + Implementation Phase (up to 24 months). That is what assessors expect.

8

Mistake: Ignoring word limits

Going far over 500 words, or writing two sentences for a 500-word section.

Fix: Respect the limits. A tight 350-word response beats a padded 600-word one. Every sentence must earn its place.

9

Mistake: Inconsistency with supporting statement

Your DILP and supporting statement describe different sectors, goals, or plans.

Fix: Read both documents side by side before submitting. Use the DILP to expand on — not contradict — your supporting statement.

CHAPTER 10

Final Tips / Direct Advice on completing your DILP

> *"The Australia Awards program is a prestigious and highly competitive scholarship. Use this information to make your application as strong as you can through having an effective and meaningful Development Impact and Linkages Plan."*

Tip 1

Give the DILP your close attention

It is an important part of the application process. Assessors can immediately tell whether a DILP was written carefully over several weeks, or rushed the day before the deadline.

Tip 2

Make a draft — then put it aside

Write your first draft. Set it aside for at least 48 hours. Return with fresh eyes. The best DILPs are revised 3–5 times before submission.

Tip 3

Have someone you trust read it

Ask a colleague, mentor, or trusted friend: "Does this sound credible? Is the problem clear? Are the activities achievable? Does everything connect?"

Tip 4

Don't leave it until the last minute

On the final day before the deadline you need to have already completed your DILP. The 14:00 AEST deadline on 30 April has no exceptions.

Tip 5

You don't need to fill every word

A clear, specific 350-word response beats a vague, padded 500-word one. But one or two sentences is clearly insufficient.

Tip 6

Ensure consistency with your supporting statement

Your DILP must be consistent with your online supporting statement — but not identical. Use the DILP to expand on your supporting statement with more depth.

CHAPTER 11

Pre-Submission Checklist

Tick every box before uploading to OASIS

Go through every item below before uploading your DILP. Do not submit without completing this.

PART 1 — PREPARING FOR YOUR SCHOLARSHIP

- ☐ Selected up to two priority sectors that match my professional background AND my proposed course
- ☐ Written a contribution statement naming a specific, real problem I face in my current job
- ☐ Quantified the problem — number of people affected, scale, cause, and consequences
- ☐ Explained the technical gap my study will fill — specifically, not generically
- ☐ Listed five technical skills directly relevant to my problem and proposed course
- ☐ Selected 2–3 competencies and written specific, honest elaborations for each
- ☐ Identified 2–3 linkage activities beyond the academic campus — named and specific
- ☐ Named specific Australian organisations with the nature of each partnership described
- ☐ Explained why each organisation is relevant to my development plan

PART 2 — DEVELOPMENT LEADERSHIP PLAN

- ☐ Written a specific, descriptive title for my proposed activity
- ☐ Addressed all four elements in the Rationale: problem, importance, how AAS helps, outcomes
- ☐ All activities are practical, doable, and within my own professional capacity and authority
- ☐ Activities follow a logical progression: plan, fund, execute, monitor, sustain
- ☐ Measures of success are specific, measurable, and within my ability to collect
- ☐ Tangible outputs identified separately from intended outcomes
- ☐ Beneficiaries named with approximate numbers
- ☐ Partners listed with specific areas of collaboration
- ☐ Resources and their sources realistically identified
- ☐ Three real challenges addressed with credible mitigating actions each
- ☐ Climate change prompt addressed in the challenges section

FINAL CHECKS BEFORE UPLOADING TO OASIS

- ☐ DILP is consistent with (but not identical to) my online supporting statement
- ☐ All word limits respected — no section exceeds 500 words
- ☐ Someone I trust has read the DILP and I have incorporated their feedback
- ☐ Final version completed at least 24 hours before the deadline
- ☐ All sections complete — no blank fields in the DILP template
- ☐ Document uploaded to OASIS before 30 April 14:00 AEST

Get your DILP reviewed by a successful Australia Awards scholar

Our team includes Australia Awards scholars who have written winning DILPs and been assessed by official DFAT panels. We offer personalised, written feedback on your DILP draft before you submit.

australiaawardshub.com/contact.html

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